

# The Signaling Gap:

State-Owned Media and the Strategic Management of Sentiment during the Russian Invasion of Ukraine

Donald Moratz

Political Science



Photo: REUTERS/Carlos Barria February 24, 2022

# The Bind

Your treaty ally just invaded  
a sovereign state.

You can't condemn them —  
they guarantee your  
security.

You can't stay silent — the  
West is watching.



Photo: UN Photo/Mark Garten February, 25 2022

# The Hidden Channel



We think state media is for the masses. The CIA thinks it's for them.

# The Gap

## Academics

- Agenda setting & framing
- Spin dictators & censorship
- Domestic opinion formation

## Practitioners

- Window into regime preferences
- Shifts in tone = policy signals
- 80+ years of institutional practice

*We formalize what practitioners have known*

# Why the Signal Works

## Readable

Everyone knows state media is state-controlled. Deviation is informative.

## Costly

Negative coverage of your patron risks retaliation from Moscow.

## Deniable

"We don't control the press." Institutional separation protects the relationship.



# Data & Design

174K

Articles

11 countries, 62 sources

GPT-4o

Sentiment

F1 = .92 vs. human coders

RD

In Time

Feb, 24 2022 as cutoff

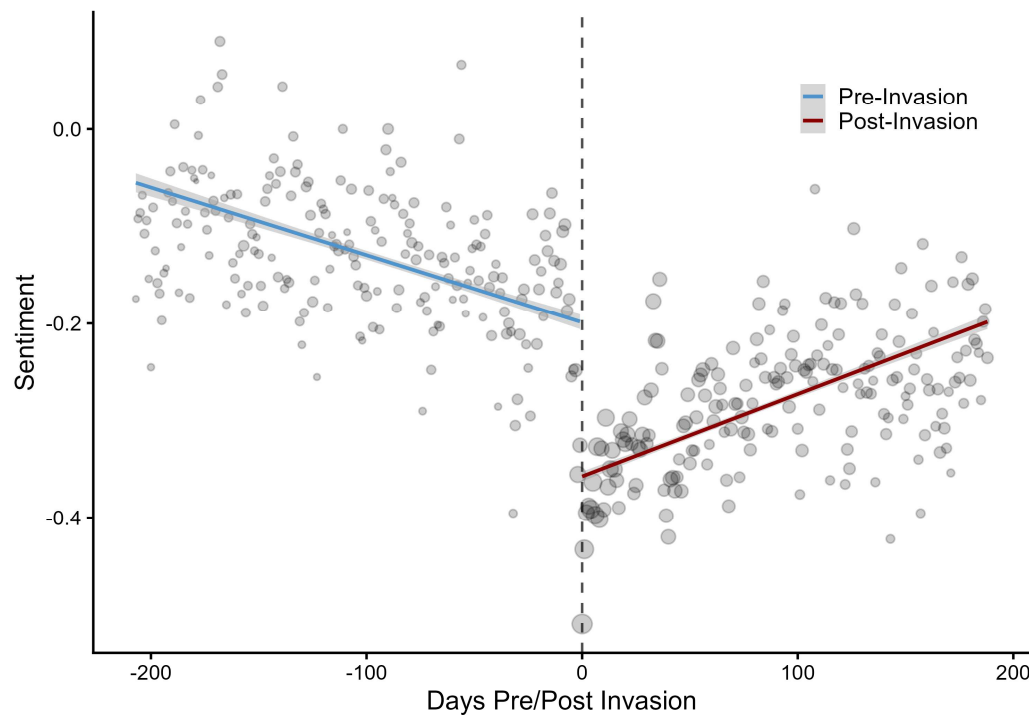
3

Groups

Russia-aligned, Neutral, NATO

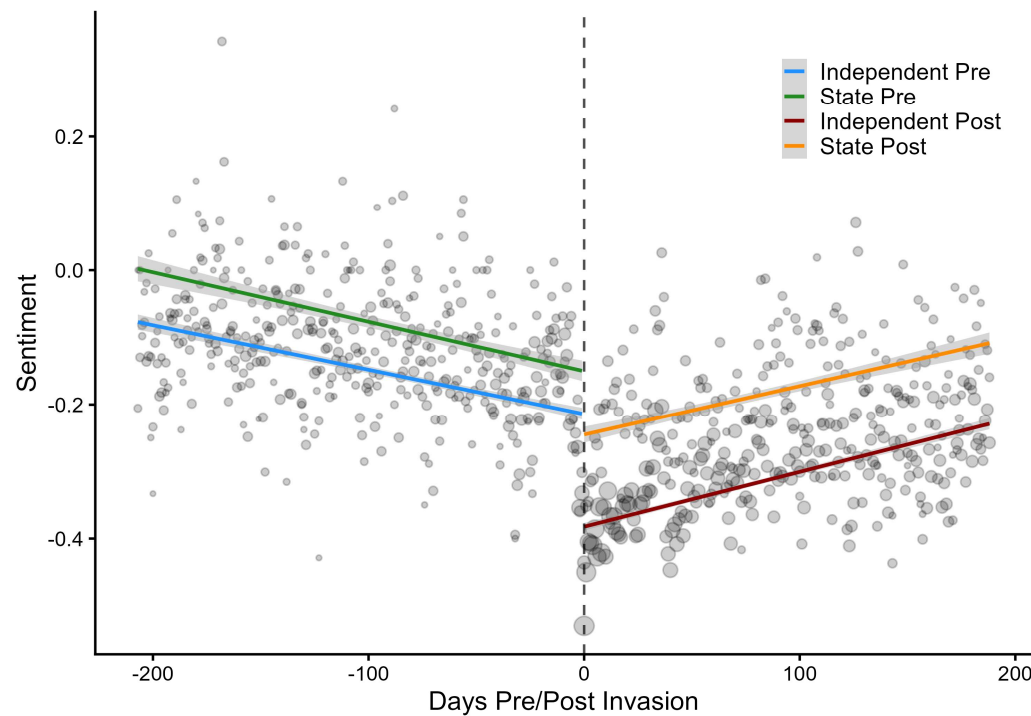
# The Shock

The invasion produced a sharp negative shock across all media.



# State Media is Different

State media responded less negatively than independent media.





# Two Predictions

## Domestic Propaganda

Suppress negative coverage to protect the alliance →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *least* negative.

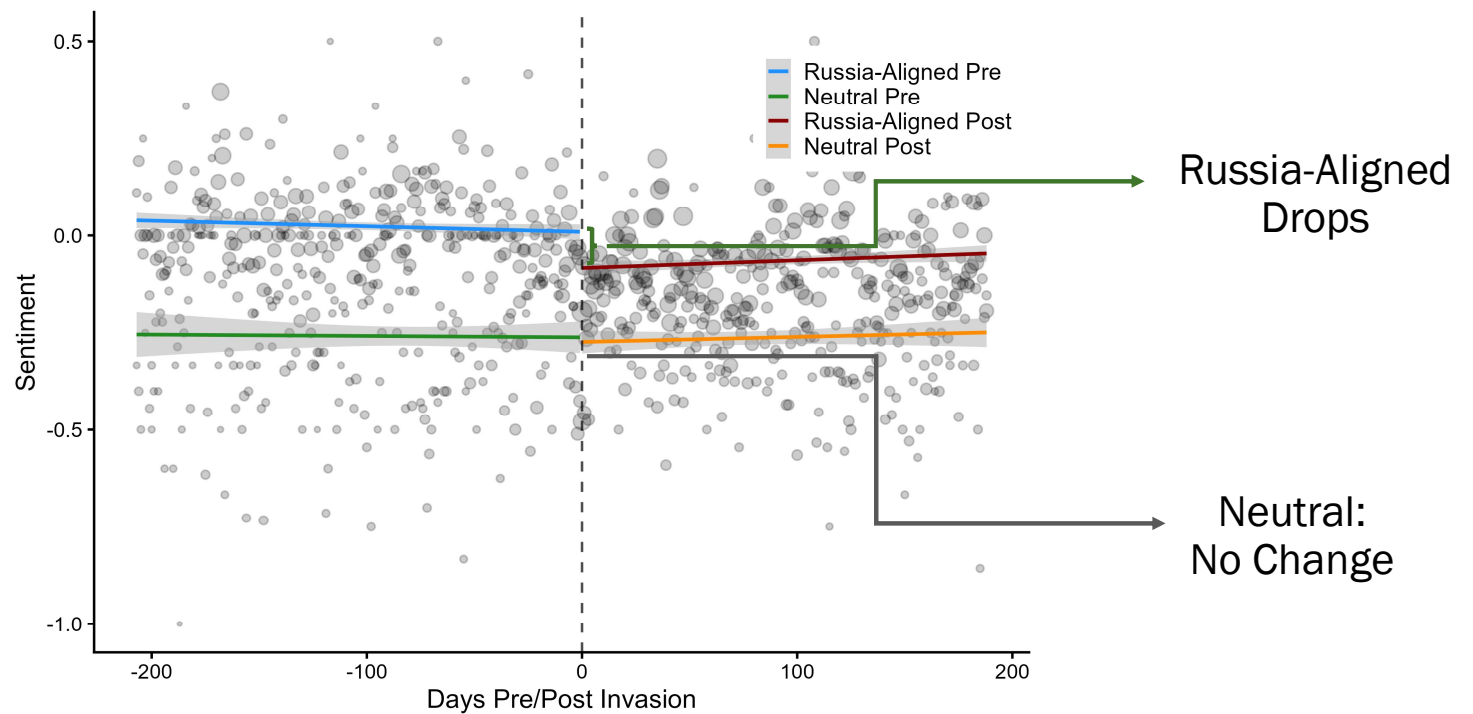
## Signaling

Amplify through informal channels because formal ones are locked →

Russia-aligned state media should be the *most* negative.

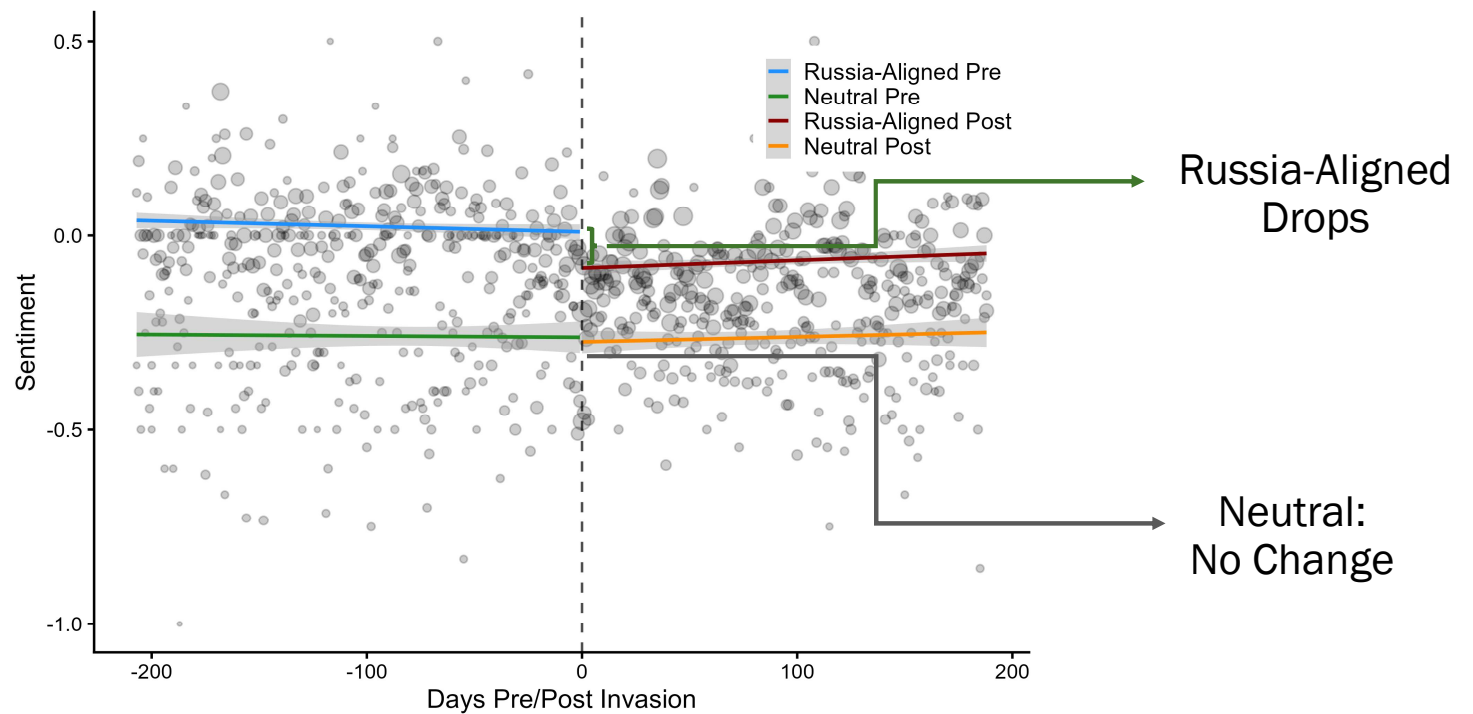
# The Counterintuitive Finding

Russia's allies went more negative — not less.



# The Counterintuitive Finding

Russia's allies went more negative — not less.



# Beyond International Relations

Constrained communication is universal. When formal channels are blocked, actors find informal ones — in any hierarchy, not just international relations.

The theory-practice gap is a method. What do practitioners in your field know that we haven't studied yet?

LLMs unlock questions at scale. 174K articles, one model, .92 accuracy — this wasn't possible five years ago.

# Thank You

Donald Moratz  
dmoratz@sas.upenn.edu

The Signaling Gap



Photo: REUTERS/Carlos Barria February 24, 2022